

First, colonisation is a debilitating, almost emaciating experience for the colonised. The vanquished are threatened with the loss of their language, culture and even identity. But then, as Varma recalls in the anecdotal part of the book, a woman set off a burglar alarm by walking up to the terrace of a Paris hotel some years ago to observe karva chauth. Personally, I believe it is a disgraceful ritual, but surely it proves our traditions are alive and kicking even if we hanker for Western certificates and have made an art of speaking and writing appalling English as Varma rightly laments.

Similarly, I was unimpressed with the author's discovery of Edwin Lutyens' letters in which the creator of New Delhi displays repulsive racial hatred and imperial arrogance towards Indians. It is not my intention to defend Lutyens, but I don't think history should judge him by his private views, which were reflective of widely held opinions of the same people that hailed General Dyer for organising the Jallianwala Bagh massacre.

But considering how CPWD has raped Delhi by erecting ungainly matchbox-like structures such as Shastri Bhawan where Varma has served, Lutyens

What I found somewhat baffling was Varma's chronicling of commonplace accounts of the racial prejudices of early English rulers.

should be complimented for keeping the city's lungs green. I also fail to see Varma's reasoning in lambasting Le Corbusier for building a "heartless" Chandigarh, when history books laud Harappan cities for similar geometric planning.

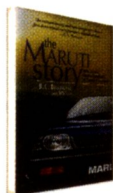
When I was a student at Oxford, studying for my doctorate under Tapan Raychaudhuri at whose house Varma enjoyed a hearty Bengali meal, several seminars were held on the subject of "reverse colonialism", a fear that gripped a section of English academia. While I agree with Varma that Nirad C. Chaudhuri, whose pathetic idiosyncrasies were discussed at that dinner, failed miserably to be accepted as more English than the English, there is little to exult about NRIS' success stories in Britain by way of contrast.

Colonialism, I hope, is over for good. What the British did to our civilisation is not to be lauded, but at least they didn't go about smashing our idols and grand temples. And the English language they bequeathed, (even if the Queen isn't amused by the way she is spoke by 125 million of her ancestors' subjects), is indeed the passport with which we have forayed into the Brave New World. I think we should stop cribbing about it. ■

Wheels of Change

The inspirational saga of how a small car revolutionised Indian roads

| By Shankkar Aiyar |



THE MARUTI STORY
by R.C. BHARGAVA
WITH SEETHA
Collins Business
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 408

Until the early 1980s, you could buy any car in India as long as it was a Premier Padmini or an Ambassador. In 1983, a little car with a rather unusual badge made its appearance: the Maruti. *The Maruti Story* by R.C. Bhargava and Seetha is the saga of this game changer, of how Sanjay Gandhi's dream of making a small car was, in the years following his death, revived as a Public Sector Unit. It was also the first time the Government of India took a major step in opening the sector to FDI by

indicating a 40 per cent stake for a foreign player. To appreciate this "one big step for a small car", one only has to see the Suzuki balance sheet where Indian operations contribute the biggest slice of revenue.

It could not have been easy for a party which swore by "garibi hatao" to actually get into producing what until then was seen as a mode of transport of the rich. It must have been harder to promise foreign investment because just four years earlier, IBM and Coke had been thrown out of the country. But then Congressmen are nothing if not innovative. To circumvent the optics of being seen as pro-rich and to conform to the requirements of "pro-poor socialism", the Congress declared Maruti as the "people's car". Thanks to the sanctity the project got because of the involvement of the first family, a team constituting some of the best minds in Indian public sector, including Bhargava, came together to create history.

Interestingly, they had set themselves a target of one lakh cars a year and so accurate was the plan that by May 1994, Maruti had sold a million cars. Today, Indians buy one lakh-plus cars a month. This year, Maruti, which is now Suzuki, will have sold a million cars in 12 months. Today Indians can choose from 26 other makers who offer 125 models with over 400 variants for the buyers to choose from at prices ranging from about a lakh for a Nano to a few crores for a Maybach. Virtually every brand on global roads is parked in India and revving for more. Even today, Maruti nee Suzuki is the biggest player. *The Maruti Story* is a story which proves that Indians when empowered can change the course of history. It proves Indians can and therefore India will. ■